

COME TOGETHER
TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu meets Union home minister Amit Shah, Mar. 8

table for the assembly election shows that the YSRCP got 49.9 per cent, the TDP 39.2 per cent, the JSP 5.5 per cent (6.24 per cent with allies, the Communist parties and the BSP). The BJP's vote share was 0.8 per cent, less than the 1.3 per cent notched up in the NOTA category.

Jagan has been cautious in reacting to the BJP allying with TDP and JSP. On March 11, the day after the deal was struck, he was at the YSRCP Siddham rally at Medarametla in Bapatla district. He refrained from targeting the saffron party while taking jibes at Naidu and Kalyan, accusing the TDP chief of having no spine to battle the YSRCP one-on-one while he (Jagan) was fighting alone like a lion. He also harked back to 2014 when they had fought together. "The BJP-TDP-JSP alliance contested the 2014 election by promising a farm loan waiver, Mahalaxmi scheme, 3 cents land for the poor and many other things. But they never implemented anything. Remember that Chandrababu had also failed to get special category status for Andhra Pradesh. What will he do now?" asked Jagan pointedly at the rally.

Jagan's plan to ensure a second successive term as CM is a strident poll campaign whose centrepiece is the slew of well implemented welfare schemes he has launched which cover the entirety of the state. But he also knows that he cannot expect to do as well as last time. There are internal challenges as well—five of his sitting MPs have drifted to other parties. He has also taken flak in the past for his high-handedness and treatment of political rival Naidu, which has not gone down well with certain sections of the populace. This is besides the charges of Jagan being "inaccessible", levelled by his legislators and others. The CM has also alienated a section of the government employees, which could also hurt the YSRCP's prospects.

JAGAN HAS BEEN CAUTIOUS WHILE REACTING TO THE NEWS OF THE BJP ALLYING WITH TDP AND JSP

The party that is likely to get a tailwind is the BJP. The party's performance in the 2019 Lok Sabha election was dismal (0.1 per cent of the vote) and any votes that accrue from the tie-up will be a welcome boost. Some analysts argue that the deal could prove detrimental for the TDP, even drag the party down. The BJP state party chief is Daggubati Purandeswari, the elder sister of Naidu's wife Bhuvaneswari and the second daughter of TDP founder N.T. Rama Rao. They will have a lot to discuss in the coming days as the elections heat up. ■

MLAs have joined the BJP while a few senior BRS leaders are said to be in consideration for Congress tickets.

KCR's party has now found a crutch in Mayawati's BSP. The party's state unit, headed by retired IPS officer R.S. Praveen Kumar, 56, did not win any seat in the recent assembly election. KCR is banking on another calculation to salvage his party from its existential crisis. The difference in vote share between the ruling Congress and the BRS in the assembly polls was barely two per cent (39.4 per cent to the BRS' 37.3 per cent), and that may not have substantially changed. Considering the BSP polled 1.4 per cent votes, KCR is hoping the BRS-BJP alliance will be a clincher.



MOHAMMED ALEEMUDDIN

DESPERATE TIMES KCR with BSP state leader Praveen Kumar in Hyderabad, Mar. 5

Analysts says it'll be a challenge getting the votes of both parties to coalesce. The BSP may benefit more if it can make tactical gains in the seats reserved for scheduled castes. Kumar, who lost from Sirpur in the assembly election, hopes to do better in the Nagarkurnool LS seat. "The BRS is wooing him to its fold so that it can gain some crucial vote share. Moreover, Kumar is eager to be heard as a Dalit voice in the Lok Sabha," says Harathi Vageeshan of NALSAR University, Hyderabad. ■